

Thursday Plyometric Program

A 10-week jump and hop block built to sit alongside JuggernautAI Powerbuilding Combo and Year of the Engine (5-day)

How this fits the week

Plyometrics are a nervous-system stimulus, not a workout. Quality of each rep matters far more than how many you do. Because you are already lifting five days and conditioning five days, this session is deliberately small: 15 to 20 minutes of actual work, once per week.

Thursday is the slot. It is the only day with no lifting, so your nervous system is the freshest it gets. Squats are a full day behind you and upper body is a day ahead. Jumps go **before** the conditioning session, never after.

Day	Lift	Conditioning	Plyos
Mon	Back focus	Endurance (bike)	—
Tue	Comp. bench, shoulders, arms	Moderate intervals	—
Wed	Squat focus	—	Optional 5-min primer
Thu	—	Hardest intervals	Full session
Fri	Upper	Endurance / polarisation	—
Sat	Deadlift focus	—	—
Sun	—	Easy long endurance	—

Session order on Thursday

1. Warm-up (below) 2. Plyometrics 3. Rest 10 minutes 4. Year of the Engine interval session

Never reverse this. Jumping on a fatigued nervous system trains you to be slow and raises injury risk without adding any useful stimulus.

The three rules that override the sheet

1. Watch your distance, not your set count. Mark your first broad jump of the day. If any subsequent jump drops more than roughly 5 percent off that mark, the session is over, even with sets remaining. Output decay means the quality stimulus is gone and everything after it is junk fatigue.

2. Every rep is maximal or near it. Rest fully between sets. If you are breathing hard, you are doing conditioning, not plyometrics.

3. Cut, don't skip. After an unusually hard lifting week, halve the contacts rather than dropping the session. The stimulus is cheap; the fatigue is not. Consistency across the block beats any single session.

Counting contacts

A contact is one landing on one foot. A two-footed broad jump landing = 2 contacts by strict count, but this program counts by ground impacts (one landing = one contact) for simplicity, and the volumes below are calibrated that way. Do not recount and add more.

Warm-up (every session)

Not counted in session totals. Takes about 8 minutes. The point is to make your ankles and calves stiff and responsive before you ask them to absorb real force.

Movement	Dose	Purpose
Pogo hops	3 x 10	Wakes up the ankle spring; short, fast ground contacts
Ankle skips	2 x 20 m	Rhythm and elastic timing through the calf and achilles
Submaximal broad jumps	3 x 1 at ~70%	Rehearses the landing pattern before full effort

Add your normal hip and ankle mobility work before this if you use one.

The 10-week block

Weeks 1–3 — Extensive (~60 contacts)

Bilateral, stick every landing. This phase is about teaching the landing and building tissue tolerance, not chasing distance.

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Contacts	Rest
Broad jump, single effort	5 x 3	15	60 s
Box jump, step down	5 x 3	15	60 s
Lateral bound, stick 2 sec	4 x 4 per side	16	60 s
Pogo hops in place	4 x 8	32 (low intensity)	45 s

Weeks 4–6 — Unilateral and reactive (~80 contacts)

Single-leg work enters. Measure and log your broad jumps from here on; they are your progress marker for the block.

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Contacts	Rest
Broad jump, 2 continuous	5 x 2 jumps	20	90 s
Single-leg hop, straight line	4 x 4 per side	32	90 s
Bound for distance	4 x 6 contacts	24	90 s
Hurdle hops, low, continuous	3 x 5	15	90 s

Weeks 7–9 — Elastic emphasis (~90 contacts)

Depth jumps enter. These are the highest-stress sets in the block and the ones most likely to show up in Saturday's deadlifts. Start at the lower box height and only raise it if landings stay silent and controlled.

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Contacts	Rest
Depth jump from 12–16 in	5 x 3	15	2 min
Single-leg lateral hop, continuous	4 x 5 per side	40	90 s
Continuous broad jump, 3 reps	4 x 3 jumps	24	90 s
Bound for height	3 x 4	12	90 s

Week 10 — Retest

Warm-up, then three attempts at each test with full rest between. Stop after the tests; no accessory jumping. Compare against your week 4 numbers, then restart the block from week 1 with the new baseline.

Test	Attempts	What it tells you
Max broad jump	3	Horizontal power — the headline number
Max vertical jump	3	Vertical power and rate of force development
Standing triple jump	3	Elastic quality and single-leg force absorption

Progression rules between blocks

- Add contacts before you add intensity.
- Raise intensity by shortening ground contact time, not by jumping higher or adding box height.
- If broad jump distance has not moved after two full blocks, the limiter is usually recovery or strength, not jump volume. Look at the rest of the week before adding more jumps.

Exercise library

Each entry covers setup, execution, what to feel, and the errors that matter. Read these once properly; the sheet above assumes you know them.

Pogo hop

Setup. Stand tall, feet hip width, arms at your sides or lightly bent. Weight on the balls of your feet.

Execution. Hop straight up repeatedly using only the ankles. Knees stay nearly straight and barely bend. Height is small — two to four inches. The goal is the shortest possible time on the ground, not air time.

Cues. Think 'stiff spring.' Toes pulled up toward your shin before you land so the forefoot contacts first. The rhythm should sound fast and even.

Common errors. Bending the knees to create height, which turns it into a squat jump and removes the ankle stimulus. Landing flat-footed or heel-first. Letting the rhythm slow as the set goes on.

Note. This is the lowest-stress drill in the program and the one that most directly builds the achilles and calf stiffness everything else relies on.

Ankle skip

Setup. Standing, ready to travel forward over about 20 metres.

Execution. Skip forward driving off the ankle with a minimal knee bend, opposite arm swinging. Cover ground with quick, light contacts rather than big bounds.

Cues. Light and quick. Contacts should be barely audible.

Common errors. Turning it into a powerful A-skip with high knee drive — that is a different drill and adds fatigue you do not want before the main sets.

Broad jump (single effort)

Setup. Feet hip to shoulder width behind a line. Clear landing space of at least 3 metres. A flat, non-slip surface; grass or rubber gym flooring is ideal, concrete is the worst option.

Execution. Hinge and load by dipping to roughly a quarter squat, swinging the arms back. Jump forward and slightly up, driving the arms forward and fully extending hips, knees and ankles. Land on both feet with hips back and knees tracking over toes, then absorb and stick — no extra hop, no stagger.

Cues. Reach, don't fall. Drive the arms hard; they contribute more distance than most people expect. Land like you are catching yourself in a quarter squat, not a deep one.

Common errors. Landing stiff-legged with straight knees (jarring and risky). Knees collapsing inward on landing. Piking at the waist in the air. Taking a step after landing — if you cannot stick it, you jumped past your current ability to absorb it.

Note. This is your measured lift for the block. Mark the takeoff line and measure to your rearmost heel. Log the best jump of each session.

Continuous broad jump

Setup. Same as above but with space for two to three consecutive jumps.

Execution. Perform a broad jump, and the instant you land, immediately jump again with minimal time on the ground. The landing of jump one is the loading for jump two.

Cues. Rebound, don't reset. The whole point is that ground contact is short. Slightly shorter individual jumps with fast contacts beat long jumps with a pause.

Common errors. Pausing to re-set between reps, which makes it three separate single jumps. Sinking into a deep squat on each landing, which kills the elastic stimulus.

Box jump, step down

Setup. A stable box or plyo platform at a height you can land on in a quarter squat, not a deep one — typically 18 to 24 inches. Stand about a foot back.

Execution. Dip, swing the arms, and jump onto the box, landing softly on both feet with hips slightly back. Stand fully upright on top, then **step** down one foot at a time.

Cues. Soft, quiet landing. If you hear a thud, you are landing too heavily or the box is too high.

Common errors. Choosing a box so tall you have to tuck your knees to your chest to clear it — that measures hip flexibility, not power. Jumping down off the box, which adds eccentric load with none of the benefit.

Note. Always step down. Repeated jump-downs are where box jump injuries come from, and they add contacts you did not program.

Lateral bound (stick 2 seconds)

Setup. Stand on one leg. Clear space to your side. Non-slip footing matters more here than anywhere else.

Execution. Push laterally off the standing leg and land on the opposite leg. Absorb on that single leg with a soft knee and the hip loaded, and hold the landing completely still for a two-count before bounding back the other way.

Cues. Land with the knee tracking over the middle of the foot and the hip taking the load. The two-second hold is the exercise — it trains deceleration and frontal-plane control.

Common errors. Rushing the hold. Letting the knee cave inward. Landing on a stiff, straight leg. Bounding so far sideways you cannot control the landing — distance is capped by your ability to stick it.

Single-leg hop (straight line)

Setup. Balance on one leg, hands free. Flat surface with several metres ahead.

Execution. Hop forward on the same leg repeatedly, aiming for consistent distance and short contacts. Complete all reps on one leg, then switch.

Cues. Stay tall through the torso. Hips level — do not let the opposite hip drop on each landing.

Common errors. Letting distance shrink through the set. Excessive side-to-side drift. Hunching forward at the waist.

Note. Compare left to right. A noticeable asymmetry in distance or landing control is worth addressing with unilateral strength work before adding jump volume.

Single-leg lateral hop (continuous)

Setup. Balance on one leg. Optionally use a line or low object to hop over.

Execution. Hop side to side on the same leg, continuously, with short ground contacts. No pause between reps.

Cues. Small and fast beats big and slow. Knee tracks over the foot on every contact.

Common errors. Knee valgus (caving inward) as fatigue sets in — stop the set when you see it. Landing flat-footed.

Note. The highest frontal-plane demand in the program, and the most protective for ankles and knees.

Bound for distance

Setup. Space of 20 to 30 metres. Start with a few walking steps into the first bound rather than from a dead stop.

Execution. Alternate legs in exaggerated running strides, driving off one leg and landing on the other, covering as much ground per contact as possible. Opposite arm drives forward with each bound.

Cues. Push the ground behind you and reach with the landing leg. Long, powerful, rhythmic.

Common errors. Turning it into ordinary running. Landing heel-first. Leaning back to try to hang in the air.

Bound for height

Setup. Same as bounding for distance, with the same run-in.

Execution. Alternate-leg bounds emphasising vertical displacement rather than horizontal — drive the knee up and get as high as you can per contact, covering less ground.

Cues. Punch the knee up and the arms up. Think 'up' on every contact.

Common errors. Drifting back into distance bounding once you fatigue. Collapsing into a deep knee bend on landing.

Hurdle hop (low, continuous)

Setup. Three to five low hurdles, cones, or 6 to 12 inch objects in a line, roughly a metre apart. Use objects that fall over harmlessly if clipped.

Execution. Hop over each with both feet, landing and immediately rebounding into the next with minimal ground contact. Complete the line, walk back, repeat.

Cues. Minimal time on the ground. Land on the balls of the feet, ankles stiff.

Common errors. Hurdles too high, which forces a knee tuck and a long pause on each landing. Pausing between hurdles to re-set.

Note. If you only have one or two objects, use fewer and reset between passes rather than raising the height.

Depth jump

Setup. Box 12 to 16 inches high. Stand at the edge. Landing area must be flat and non-slip with room to jump forward or up.

Execution. **Step** off the box — do not jump off or down. Land on both feet on the balls of the feet and, as fast as humanly possible, rebound into a maximal vertical jump. The time between landing and takeoff is the entire exercise.

Cues. Land and leave. Imagine the floor is hot. Target roughly a quarter-second on the ground; if you sink into a deep squat before jumping, the box is too high.

Common errors. Jumping off the box instead of stepping, which changes the landing force unpredictably. Using too high a box — the single most common error, and it converts an elastic drill into a heavy eccentric one. Pausing on landing.

Note. Highest-stress movement in the program. If your vertical rebound off the box is lower than a normal standing vertical jump, the box is too high — lower it. Start at 12 inches even if that feels trivially easy.

Logging sheet

Record the best broad jump each session and note anything that felt off. The trend over 10 weeks is the signal; any single session is noise.

Week	Date	Best broad jump	Contacts done	Notes
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				

When to pull back

Cut the session in half, or skip to the warm-up only, if any of these are true on the day:

- Broad jump distance is down more than 5 percent from your recent sessions before you have even started the work sets.
- Achilles, patellar tendon or shin soreness that you can feel while walking. Tendon complaints build quietly over weeks and then stop you for months.
- Sleep has been short or broken for several nights running.
- Wednesday's squat session was unusually heavy or left you sore into Thursday.

Appetite and sleep slip before your numbers do. Those are your earliest warning that the combined load of lifting, conditioning and jumping has gone past what you are recovering from.